

Election Forecast — Tester Guide

Live app: <https://election-forecast-silk.vercel.app>

A plain-English walkthrough of what the dashboard shows, how to read it, and exactly what to click to try it yourself.

1. The big idea (read this first)

On election night, raw numbers ("Candidate X leads by 12,000") don't tell you much on their own — you need a **reference point**. This dashboard's reference point is **the last election's certified result** (2020 for President, the most recent Senate race per state).

So every number is really answering one question:

Is this area doing better or worse than last time — and what does that mean for who wins?

That comparison ("the shift") is the heart of everything you see.

Two terms used everywhere: - **Two-party share** — the Democrat's share of just the D+R vote (ignoring third parties). "50.1%" means 50.1% of the two-party vote. - **Shift** — how much the Democrat is over/under-performing vs the baseline, in percentage points. Shown as **D+1.9** (Democrats doing better) or **R+2.3** (Republicans doing better). Blue = D gain, red = R gain.

2. The screen layout

Eight swing states across the top. Below that: a Scenario/Reset/Next-Batch simulator bar, a President/Senate/GA-Special race toggle, and the main panels — live vote bar, win-probability gauge, convergence chart, county shift bars, county table, plus a Watch List, EV Tracker, and County Insight box on the right.

3. Panel-by-panel — what to see & what to look for

Swing-State Strip (top row). Eight clickable cards: state + electoral votes, lean (e.g. "Tilt D 60.1%"), % reporting, shift vs baseline. Blue top-border = currently Democratic, red = Republican. Click any card to drill into it.

Election dropdown. Pick which election you're viewing — only the races on that ballot appear (Demo sandbox, historical replays, or the real Nov 3, 2026 general).

Race Toggle. President | Senate | GA Special.

Live Vote Bar. The two candidates, live totals, percentages, and who leads by how much. Remember an early lead can be misleading (see "red mirage" below).

Convergence Chart. The live Democratic two-party % as precincts report, against a dashed flat line = the baseline. Solid blue while the Democrat is at/above 50%; dashed blue while below 50%.

Win Probability Gauge. A needle between DEM (blue) and REP (red), with a lean label ("Tilt D", "Safe R"...) and a confidence tier ("Very Early" → "Near Final").

County Breakdown Table. One row per county: % reporting, D% live, D% 2020, Shift, Votes In. Click a header to sort.

County Shift Bars. A bar per county — right/blue = D shift, left/red = R shift.

Watch List. Counties with the most votes still outstanding — the highest-impact places still to report.

EV Tracker. All 8 states' electoral votes + lean, with a running D vs R tally.

County Insight. Click any county in the table — plain-English readout of its share vs the 2020 benchmark, turnout vs 2020, votes pending, and which way they lean, with ballot-type tabs (All / Election-Day / Early / Mail / Military).

4. The win-probability legend

Lean labels: Safe D $\geq 97\%$ · Likely D $\geq 85\%$ · Lean D $\geq 65\%$ · Tilt D $> 55\%$ · **Toss-Up** 45–55% · Tilt R · Lean R · Likely R · Safe R (mirror).

Confidence tiers (by % reporting): Very Early ($<15\%$) · Early (15–40%) · Developing (40–70%) · Strong Signal (70–90%) · Near Final ($>90\%$).

Early on, the forecast deliberately stays close to the baseline and only trusts the live swing more as more precincts report — so a small early lead won't swing the probability much, by design.

5. How to simulate an election night

There's no live 2026 data yet, so the dashboard **replays** a real past election, revealing precincts in batches:

1. **Scenario** dropdown — pick what to replay.
2. **Reset** — clears to 0% and loads the chosen scenario.
3. **Next Batch** ■ — reveals the next ~20% of precincts. Click it five times to go 20 → 40 → 60 → 80 → 100%.

On the real election day, this button is replaced automatically by the live data poller — same dashboard, same math, only the data source changes.

6. Try it yourself — a guided tour

1. Race = **President**. Scenario = **True (real 2020 results)**. Click **Reset**, then **Next Batch** ■ a few times. Watch the "Convergence vs 2020" chart: the blue line starts at 0% at the dashed 2020 baseline, stays solid while the Democrat is $\geq 50\%$, and extends rightward without redrawing.
2. Click a state the Republican won (e.g. NC or TX) — the convergence line turns dashed, since the Democrat is below 50% there.
3. Toggle to **Senate**, select **GA**, Reset, Next Batch to 100%. You should see Jon Ossoff (D) beating David Perdue (R) — the dashboard uses the real Jan-2021 runoff as GA's Senate baseline, not the November general.
4. Click the **GA Special** toggle (Warnock vs Loeffler) — the top strip narrows to just Georgia, since this race only exists there.
5. Race = President, Scenario = "**TEST · +4% big-county turnout, by ballot type**". Reset, select GA, click Next Batch once or twice, then click the FULTON row in the county table. Open the County Insight box and try its Mail / Election-Day tabs — early on it should show Georgia's vote bar leaning Republican (the "red mirage"), with a note that uncounted mail votes (which lean Democratic) are likely to shift the result. Keep clicking Next Batch to 100% and watch the vote bar flip Democratic (the "blue shift") as mail is counted.
6. Check the **EV Tracker** on the right for the big picture across all 8 states.

7. Cheat sheet

You see	It means
D% Live vs D% 2020	tonight's Democratic share vs that area's last result. Higher = over-performing.
vs Bench	live share minus the 2020 benchmark. Green/+ = above benchmark (good for Dem).
Turn v20	estimated turnout vs 2020. Unreliable until mail is in.
Pending	estimated votes still to be counted.
Convergence line solid vs dashed	solid = Democrat above 50%; dashed = below 50%.
Mail bucket leaning D, still small	expect the Democrat to gain as mail is counted.

Win-prob gauge

chance the Democrat wins, given the projection +
how much is reported.

8. If something looks wrong

- **Blank panels / "API error":** the backend may be waking up from idle — wait a few seconds and refresh.
 - **Everything at 100% already:** click **Reset** to start from 0%.
 - **GA Special shows only one state:** that's correct — only Georgia has that race.
 - **County Insight empty:** click a county row in the table, or step at least one batch.
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9. Important caveats

- This is a **replay/simulation** of past elections until real 2026 results exist — the live-feed machinery is built and validated, but goes live only on actual primary/election nights.
- The "D+5" scenarios are synthetic hypotheticals — a real past vote map with an artificial swing applied, relabeled candidates. Not a prediction.
- Senate compares against each state's own most recent Senate race (baseline years differ by state).